The heavenly steed Al-Buraq flying to Jerusalem. A popular print from South India, c. 1910.

However, from the tenth century onwards a very different manifestation of Islam began to impact on the subcontinent, its tone set by the many warlords who descended on Northern India by way of Afghanistan in search of plunder and slaves while claiming to be acting as servants of Allah, among them the Mongol Timur the Lame.

After sacking Delhi with great slaughter in the year 1398, Timur pondered on what he perceived to be his religious duty. 'I then reflected that I had come to Hindustan to war against infidels,' he wrote in his autobiography. 'I had put to death some *lacs* [1 lac = 100,000] of infidels and idolaters, and I had stained my proselytising sword with the blood of the enemies of the faith.'[3]

Again, we have to be extremely wary of such boasts, yet it is hard to avoid the conclusion that Timur's concept of the 'proselytising sword' did indeed manifest itself in India to a degree, that iconoclasm did take place and that slavery was endemic. There was undoubtedly a slave trade into Central Asia, which is memorialised in the name given to the slave trail through the mountains of Afghanistan to Samarkand and the Khanates. 'Upon this road there is a mountain called *Hindu kush*, which means "the slayer of the Indians",' noted the fourteenth-century Berber traveller Ibn Battuta in his *Rihla*, 'because the slave boys and girls who are brought from the land of India die there in large numbers as a result of the extreme cold and the great quantity of snow.'[4]

However, context is everything and slavery has been a feature of virtually every society since the dawn of recorded history, with Hindu India no exception. The *Manusmriti* lists seven different categories of *dasa*, and Chanakya takes much the same line when setting out the rights of slaves in his *Arthashastra*. Islam recognised slavery as an outcome of *ghanim*, or 'spoils of war', and as a means of winning